

The Anxiety & Resilience System

Subtitle: Cognitive Frameworks & Calming Scripts for Neurodivergent Minds **Theme:** Managing anxiety, worry, fears, and overthinking through actionable systems.

START HERE — PICK YOUR ANXIETY TYPE

Anxiety is a shapeshifter. Identify the specific beast you are fighting today.

● If they are spiraling or panicking right now:

- **Use Tool #1:** The "Mammalian Dive" Protocol (Physical Reset)
- **Use Tool #2:** The 5-4-3-2-1 Grounding Script
- **Use Tool #5:** The Panic Attack "Ride the Wave" Visualization

● If they constantly ask "What If?":

- **Use Tool #9:** The Worry Parking Lot System
- **Use Tool #10:** The Probability Calculator (Logic Check)
- **Use Tool #14:** The "Lizard Brain" Explainer

● If they are terrified of School or Separation:

- **Use Tool #17:** The "Invisible String" Connection Script
- **Use Tool #21:** The School "Safe Person" Map
- **Use Tool #23:** The "Bridge" Transition Object

● If they cannot sleep due to racing thoughts:

- **Use Tool #26:** The Bedtime Brain Dump
- **Use Tool #28:** The "Dream Channel Changer"
- **Use Tool #30:** The "Monster Spray" Placebo Protocol

Section 1: In-The-Moment Relief (The Parachute)

Stopping the spiral when logic has left the building.

1. The "Mammalian Dive" Protocol

Best Used When Your child is in a 10/10 panic state, hyperventilating, or hysterical.

What This Helps With • Physiological reset • Lowering heart rate • Breaking the panic loop

Plaintext My child is in a high-state panic. Explain the "Mammalian Dive Reflex" (using ice water/cold pack on the face) to me. Give me a calm, clear script to guide them through this physical reset to instantly lower their heart rate.

Parent Note: *You cannot talk them out of a panic attack. You have to physically reset the system.*

2. The 5-4-3-2-1 Grounding Script

Best Used When Your child feels "floaty," dissociated, or overwhelmed by thoughts.

What This Helps With • Grounding in reality • Distraction • Sensory awareness

Plaintext We need a grounding exercise. Write a gentle script for the "5-4-3-2-1 Game." Ask them to name: 5 things they see, 4 they can touch, 3 they hear, 2 they smell, and 1 good thing about themselves.

Parent Note: *Bring them back to the 'here and now' before they get lost in the 'what if'.*

3. The "Square Breathing" Visual

Best Used When Your child is breathing shallowly but is too anxious to follow verbal instructions.

What This Helps With • Breath control • Visual focus • Vagus nerve stimulation

Plaintext My child can't follow verbal breathing instructions. Describe how to use a physical object (like a window or a book) to trace "Square Breathing" (In 4, Hold 4, Out 4, Hold 4) with their finger while they breathe.

Parent Note: *Tracing the shape gives the restless energy somewhere to go.*

4. The "Name It to Tame It" Script

Best Used When Your child is flooded with big emotions and can't speak.

What This Helps With • Emotional granularity • Reducing intensity • Communication

Plaintext My child is flooded. Give me a script to help them "Name the Feeling." "It looks like [Emotion] has visited you. Is it big like a bear or stinging like a bee?" Help us externalize the feeling so it's not *them*, it's just *visiting* them.

Parent Note: *A feeling that has a name is a feeling that can be managed.*

5. The "Ride the Wave" Visualization

Best Used When Your child is afraid the anxiety will never end.

What This Helps With • Acceptance • Endurance • Reducing resistance

Plaintext My child thinks this panic will last forever. Give me a "Surfer" visualization script. Explain that anxiety is like a wave—it goes up, it peaks, and it *always* comes down. We just have to surf it to the shore.

Parent Note: *Fighting the wave causes drowning. Floating on it saves energy.*

6. The "Squeeze and Release" (PMR) Tool

Best Used When Your child's body is stiff, tense, or trembling.

What This Helps With • Muscle relaxation • Body awareness • Physical release

Plaintext Guide us through "Progressive Muscle Relaxation" for kids. Give me a script that uses metaphors (e.g., "Squeeze a lemon in your hand," "Hide your head like a turtle") to tense and release muscles.

Parent Note: *Relaxing the body tricks the brain into thinking it is safe.*

7. The Distraction Challenge Script

Best Used When You need to snap them out of a loop immediately.

What This Helps With • Cognitive shifting • Interrupting patterns • Focus

Plaintext We need a "Cognitive Interruption." Give me 3 hard mental questions to ask my child (e.g., "Spell your name backward," "Count backward from 20 by 2s") to force their thinking brain to come back online.

Parent Note: *The brain cannot panic and do math at the same time.*

8. The "Safe Place" Mental Blueprint

Best Used When The environment is too loud or scary and they need an escape.

What This Helps With • Dissociation (healthy) • Self-soothing • Visualization

Plaintext Help us build a "Mental Safe Place." Ask my child specific questions to design an imaginary room or forest (e.g., "What does it smell like? Who is there?"). Give me a script to guide them there when they are scared.

Parent Note: *Imagination is their superpower. Use it for safety, not just fear.*

Section 2: Worry Management Systems (The Container)

Systems to hold the worry so the child doesn't have to.

9. The Worry Parking Lot System

Best Used When Your child interrupts the day constantly with random worries.

What This Helps With • Deferring worry • Staying present • Validation

Plaintext My child worries all day long. Help us build a "Worry Parking Lot." Explain the rules: When a worry comes, we write it down and "park it" for later. We only check the parking lot at [Specific Time].

Parent Note: *We aren't ignoring the worry; we are scheduling it.*

10. The Probability Calculator (Logic Check)

Best Used When Your child is convinced a rare catastrophe (e.g., asteroid) will happen.

What This Helps With • Reality testing • Math vs. Fear • Perspective

Plaintext My child is catastrophizing about [Event]. Act as a "Probability Detective." Help us make a list of: 1. What is the Worst that could happen? 2. What is the Best that could happen? 3. What is *Most Likely* to happen?

Parent Note: *Fear confuses 'possible' with 'probable'. Logic separates them.*

11. The "Worry Bully" Personification

Best Used When Your child believes everything their anxiety tells them.

What This Helps With • Externalization • Critical thinking • Empowerment

Plaintext Help my child name their anxiety (e.g., "The Worry Bully" or "Reviewer #2"). Give me a script to help them talk back to it: "Thanks for the warning, Bob, but we've got this handled."

Parent Note: *Make the anxiety a separate character so they can disagree with it.*

12. The "Circle of Control" Map

Best Used When Your child is anxious about things they cannot fix (weather, other people).

What This Helps With • Focus • Acceptance • Reducing helplessness

Plaintext Create a text-based "Circle of Control" activity. Help us list things inside the circle (My words, My choices) and outside the circle (The weather, other kids). Give me a mantra: "If it's not in the circle, I let it go."

Parent Note: *Peace comes from knowing what is yours to carry.*

13. The Evidence Log (Courtroom Style)

Best Used When Your child predicts failure ("I'm going to fail the test").

What This Helps With • Cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT) basics • Fact-checking • Confidence

Plaintext My child thinks [Bad Thing] will happen. Let's go to "Court." Help us list "Evidence For" and "Evidence Against" this thought. Help the child act as the Judge to decide if the thought is guilty of lying.

Parent Note: *Feelings are real, but thoughts are not always facts.*

14. The "Lizard Brain" Explainer

Best Used When Your child feels broken or "crazy" because they get scared easily.

What This Helps With • Psychoeducation • Reducing shame • Understanding biology

Plaintext Explain the amygdala ("Lizard Brain") to a child. Use the metaphor of a "Safety Alarm" that is a little too sensitive/glitchy. Reassure them that their brain is trying to protect them, it just needs a software update.

Parent Note: *Their brain isn't broken; it's just trying too hard to keep them safe.*

15. The "Maybe" Game

Best Used When Your child demands certainty ("Promise me nothing bad will happen").

What This Helps With • Tolerating uncertainty • Flexibility • Moving away from black-and-white thinking

Plaintext My child demands certainty. Teach us the "Maybe" game to practice uncertainty. Script: "Maybe it will rain, maybe it won't. If it does, we have umbrellas. If it doesn't, we play outside. We can handle both."

Parent Note: *The goal isn't certainty; the goal is confidence in handling the unknown.*

16. The "Scheduled Worry Time" Ritual

Best Used When Worry takes over bedtime.

What This Helps With • Boundaries • Sleep hygiene • Containment

Plaintext We need to set up "Worry Time." Give me the rules for a 15-minute daily session (early evening) where we sit down and worry *on purpose* as hard as we can, so we don't have to do it at bedtime.

Parent Note: *Contain the worry to a specific time slot so it doesn't bleed into the whole day.*

Section 3: School & Separation Anxiety (The Bridge)

Crossing the gap between home and the world.

17. The "Invisible String" Connection Script

Best Used When Your child cries when you leave them at school.

What This Helps With • Object permanence • Connection • Security

Plaintext My child has separation anxiety. Based on the concept of the "Invisible String," give me a script to tell them that we are always connected by a heart-string, even when we can't see each other. Suggest a physical gesture (tugging on the heart) to check the connection.

Parent Note: *Distance is physical, but connection is emotional.*

18. The "Morning Transfer" Huddle

Best Used When Drop-off is chaotic and terrifying.

What This Helps With • Signaling safety • Transitioning authority • Routine

Plaintext Design a "Drop-Off Handover" ritual. Give me a script for the "Huddle": 1. Make eye contact. 2. Say "I am transferring the 'Keeping You Safe' job to [Teacher's Name]." 3. Give the "See you later" specific time (e.g., "After snack").

Parent Note: *They need to know who is in charge of their safety when you leave.*

19. The "Brave Button" Anchor

Best Used When Your child feels small and powerless at school.

What This Helps With • Anchoring • Confidence • Tactile support

Plaintext We want to draw a "Brave Button" on my child's wrist (or sew a button inside their sleeve). Give me a script to "charge it up" with love in the morning, so they can press it whenever they feel scared at school.

Parent Note: *A little magic goes a long way.*

20. The "After School" Visualization Plan

Best Used When Your child refuses to get out of the car.

What This Helps With • Future thinking • Motivation • Reducing immediate dread

Plaintext My child refuses to go into school. Help me pivot their brain to the future. "Let's plan what we will do the *second* I pick you up." Help us choose a specific, fun reunion activity to focus on instead of the separation.

Parent Note: *Focus on the reunion, not the separation.*

21. The School "Safe Person" Map

Best Used When School feels like a hostile, giant ocean.

What This Helps With • Identifying resources • Safety planning • Reducing isolation

Plaintext School feels too big. Help us create a "Safe Person Map." Who can they go to in the cafeteria? Recess? The library? List 3 specific adults or peers they can find if they feel panic rising.

Parent Note: *Safety is people, not just places.*

22. The "Data Collection" Mission

Best Used When Your child is convinced "everyone hates me" or "I will fail."

What This Helps With • Cognitive shifting • Observation • Fact-checking

Plaintext My child thinks school is scary. Turn them into a "Scientist." Give them a mission: "Today, count how many people smile at you" or "Count how many times the teacher helps someone." Report back the data.

Parent Note: *Change their lens from 'victim' to 'observer'.*

23. The "Bridge" Transition Object

Best Used When Your child needs a physical piece of you.

What This Helps With • Sensory connection • Reducing loneliness • Comfort

Plaintext My child needs a transition object. Suggest 3 low-profile items (e.g., a laminated photo in a locket, a note in the lunchbox, a matching bracelet) that act as a "Bridge" between home and school without being distracting.

Parent Note: *A piece of home makes the world feel safer.*

24. The Sunday Night Preview

Best Used When The "Sunday Scaries" start at 4 PM.

What This Helps With • Preparation • Reducing unknown variables • Calming the nervous system

Plaintext We have the "Sunday Scaries." Create a "Week Preview" checklist. We look at the calendar, see exactly what is happening each day (gym day? pizza day?), and lay out the uniform. Knowledge kills fear.

Parent Note: *Anxiety hates a plan.*

Section 4: Nighttime & Sleep Anxiety (The Sunset)

Quieting the mind when the lights go out.

25. The "Bad Thought" Shredder

Best Used When Your child confesses all their bad thoughts right at bedtime.

What This Helps With • Clearing the mind • Visualization • Closure

Plaintext My child's brain spins at night. Teach us the "Mental Shredder." We talk about the bad thoughts, imagine writing them on paper, and then mentally shredding them or putting them in a locked box until morning.

Parent Note: *Don't let them sleep with their worries. Put the worries to bed first.*

26. The Bedtime Brain Dump

Best Used When "I can't sleep because I might forget to do X."

What This Helps With • Offloading memory • Reassurance • Sleep hygiene

Plaintext My child is afraid of forgetting things. Create a "Nightstand Notebook" ritual. Give me a script: "Get it out of your head and onto the paper. The paper will remember it for you so you can sleep."

Parent Note: *The brain can't rest if it's holding onto a To-Do list.*

27. The Gratitude Bookend

Best Used When The day ended on a sour, anxious note.

What This Helps With • Positive psychology • Rewiring the brain • Serotonin

Plaintext We need to end the day positively. Give me a script for "3 Good Things." No matter how bad the day was, we find 3 tiny good things (a cold drink, a funny joke, a soft pillow) to "bookend" the day with safety.

Parent Note: *What you focus on grows. End the day growing the good stuff.*

28. The "Dream Channel Changer"

Best Used When Your child is terrified of nightmares.

What This Helps With • Empowerment • Lucid dreaming basics • Control

Plaintext My child is afraid of bad dreams. Give them a "Dream Remote Control." Teach them a script to say before sleep: "If I don't like the channel, I will click the button and change it to the [Favorite Activity] channel."

Parent Note: *Remind them they are the director of their own movies.*

29. The "Guard Dog" Logic (Safety Audit)

Best Used When Your child is afraid of break-ins or monsters.

What This Helps With • Logic • Safety verification • Reassurance

Plaintext My child checks the locks obsessively. Help us do a "Safety Audit." We walk to the door, check the lock *together*, and say "Locked and safe." We check the smoke detector light. "Blinking and safe."

Parent Note: *Show them the safety; don't just tell them.*

30. The "Monster Spray" Placebo Protocol

Best Used When Your young child has magical thinking fears (monsters/ghosts).

What This Helps With • Meeting them where they are • Comfort • Ritual

Plaintext My young child is scared of monsters. Help me create a label for a "Monster Spray" bottle (water + lavender). Give me a script to spray the room *with* them to create a "Forcefield of Protection."

Parent Note: *Magical fears sometimes need magical solutions.*

31. The Weighted Blanket Explainer

Best Used When Your child is restless and thrashing.

What This Helps With • Proprioception • Calming the nervous system • Security

Plaintext Explain to my child why a weighted blanket (or tight tuck-in) helps. Use the metaphor of a "Big Hug" that lasts all night long to help their muscles know it's time to turn off.

Parent Note: *Deep pressure is a 'safe' signal to the primitive brain.*

32. The Audio Anchor Strategy

Best Used When Silence is too loud/scary.

What This Helps With • Auditory masking • Distraction • Comfort

Plaintext My child can't sleep in silence. Suggest a specific type of audio (Audiobooks they have already heard? Brown noise? Sleep stories?) that engages the brain just enough to stop worry, but not enough to keep them awake.

Parent Note: *The goal is 'boring enough to sleep, interesting enough to not think'.*

Section 5: New Situations & Uncertainty (The Map)

Facing change without freezing.

33. The "Preview" Strategy (Google Maps)

Best Used When Going to a new place (dentist, party, park) causes a meltdown.

What This Helps With • Reducing the unknown • Visualization • Familiarity

Plaintext We are going to a new place [Location]. Act as a "Scout." Tell us to look up photos of the building, the parking lot, and the inside online. Help us "walk through" the visit virtually before we go physically.

Parent Note: *Make the unknown familiar before you ever leave the house.*

34. The "Plan B" Mapping

Best Used When Your child asks "What if X goes wrong?"

What This Helps With • Problem solving • Reducing catastrophic thinking • Preparation

Plaintext My child is worried about things going wrong. Let's make a "Plan B Map." If [Bad Thing A] happens -> We do [Solution A]. If [Bad Thing B] happens -> We do [Solution B]. Write it down to show them there is a plan for the chaos.

Parent Note: *Anxiety asks 'What if?'. Resilience answers 'Even if'.*

35. The "Social Script" Rehearsal

Best Used When Social uncertainty makes them want to stay home.

What This Helps With • Confidence • Muscle memory • Reducing social load

Plaintext My child is anxious about a party. Help us script the "First 5 Minutes."

1. Where do I put my coat?
2. Who do I say hi to?
3. What do I do with my hands? Rehearse this specific sequence.

Parent Note: *The hardest part is the threshold. Script the entry.*

36. The "Exit Strategy" Permission

Best Used When Your child feels trapped.

What This Helps With • Autonomy • Safety • Willingness to try

Plaintext My child won't go because they are afraid of being stuck. Help me give them an "Exit Strategy." "We will go for 15 minutes. If you still hate it, give me the secret signal, and we leave immediately. No questions asked."

Parent Note: *Knowing the door is open makes it easier to stay in the room.*

37. The "Hard Thing" Sandwich

Best Used When They have to do something scary (shot, dentist).

What This Helps With • Motivation • Dopamine • Future focus

Plaintext We have to do a Hard Thing (Doctor). Create a "Hard Thing Sandwich." Bottom Bun: Fun Music on the way there. Meat: The Doctor visit. Top Bun: Specific Treat/Park visit immediately after. Focus on the Top Bun.

Parent Note: *Sandwich the scary stuff in safety and fun.*

38. The "Just One Step" Method

Best Used When The whole event feels too big.

What This Helps With • Breaking down tasks • Reducing overwhelm • Momentum

Plaintext My child is frozen. Help us break the event down. "We aren't going to the party. We are just putting on shoes. Okay, now we are just getting in the car." Don't talk about the destination, just the next step.

Parent Note: *Don't look at the mountain. Look at your feet.*

39. The "Uncertainty Experiment"

Best Used When Your child refuses to try new foods or games.

What This Helps With • Growth mindset • Data collection • Bravery

Plaintext My child hates new things. Frame it as an "Experiment." "We don't know if it's good or bad. We are just collecting data. If you hate it, that is valuable data. Let's find out."

Parent Note: *Curiosity is the opposite of anxiety.*

40. The "Role Model" Story

Best Used When They need inspiration.

What This Helps With • Social learning • Normalizing fear • Inspiration

Plaintext My child is scared to try [Activity]. Tell me a short story about a famous person or character (e.g., Batman, a Scientist) who was scared but did it anyway. Frame bravery as "doing it while scared," not "not being scared."

Parent Note: *Courage is not the absence of fear; it is acting in spite of it.*

Section 6: Building Long-Term Resilience (The Muscle)

Training the brain to be brave.

41. The Bravery Ladder (Exposure Therapy)

Best Used When You want to help them overcome a phobia (e.g., dogs, spiders).

What This Helps With • Systematic desensitization • Goal setting • Measuring progress

Plaintext We want to overcome a fear of [Phobia]. Help us build a "Bravery Ladder." Step 1: Look at a picture of it. Step 5: Be in the room with it. Step 10: Touch it. Break it down into tiny rungs.

Parent Note: *Climb the ladder one rung at a time.*

42. The "Yet" Statement Generator

Best Used When Your child says "I can't do it."

What This Helps With • Growth mindset • Hope • Persistence

Plaintext My child says "I can't do this." Teach us the power of "YET." Give me a script to reframe their sentences. "I can't do this... YET." "I don't know how... YET."

Parent Note: *'Yet' opens the door that 'Can't' slammed shut.*

43. The "Nervous vs. Excited" Reframe

Best Used When Your child has butterflies in their stomach.

What This Helps With • Physiological interpretation • Cognitive reframing • Performance anxiety

Plaintext My child says they are nervous (tummy hurts, heart racing). Explain that "Nervous" and "Excited" feel exactly the same in the body. Give me a script to re-label the feeling: "Your body is just revving its engine to get ready!"

Parent Note: *It's not panic; it's power.*

44. The Resilience Resume

Best Used When Your child feels weak or incapable.

What This Helps With • Self-esteem • Evidence of capability • Recall

Plaintext My child feels weak. Help us write a "Resilience Resume." List 5 hard things they have already survived or overcome (e.g., learning to walk, the first day of school, a scraped knee). Remind them they are a survivor.

Parent Note: *You have a 100% success rate of surviving bad days so far.*

45. The "Mistake Celebration" Ritual

Best Used When Your child is paralyzed by fear of failure.

What This Helps With • Perfectionism • Risk tolerance • Learning

Plaintext We are afraid of making mistakes. Create a dinner ritual called "Mistake of the Day." The parent goes first and shares a mistake they made and what they learned. Then the child shares. We clap for the learning.

Parent Note: *Make it safe to fail, so it's safe to try.*

46. The Coping Skills Menu

Best Used When Your child doesn't know what to do when upset.

What This Helps With • Preparation • Autonomy • Problem solving

Plaintext Help us create a physical "Menu" of coping skills. Appetizers (Quick fixes): 3 deep breaths, squeeze a ball. Main Course (Big fixes): Go for a run, talk to Mom. Dessert (Comfort): Cuddle the cat.

Parent Note: *When you are hungry for relief, you need a menu.*

47. The "Self-Compassion" Mantra

Best Used When Your child beats themselves up for being anxious.

What This Helps With • Reducing shame • Internal dialogue • Healing

Plaintext My child hates that they are anxious. Give me a "Self-Compassion" mantra. "It makes sense that I am scared. It is okay to be scared. I am being brave right now."

Parent Note: *Be the voice you want them to hear in their head.*

48. The Challenge Tracker (Gamification)

Best Used When You want to encourage trying new things.

What This Helps With • Motivation • Visual progress • Reward

Plaintext Create a "Brave Points" system. Every time they do something that scares them, they get a point. What is a good way to track this visually (jar of marbles? sticker chart?) for a [Age] year old?

Parent Note: *Celebrate the effort, not just the outcome.*

49. The "Sensory Armor" Check

Best Used When Your child is resilient at home but falls apart in loud places.

What This Helps With • Sensory defense • Preparation • Endurance

Plaintext My child needs "Sensory Armor" to be brave in the world. List the essential kit: Noise-canceling headphones, sunglasses, hoodie, fidgets. Explain that wearing armor isn't weakness; it's smart preparation.

Parent Note: *Don't send a knight into battle without their shield.*

50. The "Letter to Future Me"

Best Used When Your child is in a good headspace.

What This Helps With • Hope • Perspective • Time travel

Plaintext Help my child write a letter to "Future Me" who is having a panic attack. "Dear Future Me, I know you are scared right now, but remember..." Fill in the blanks with advice from their calm self.

Parent Note: *Their calm self is the best therapist for their anxious self.*

Bonus: System Customization Worksheet

1. Change the Persona

- *"Act as a Jedi Master teaching a Padawan about fear..."*
- *"Act as a warm, funny Grandma..."*
- *"Act as a scientist analyzing data..."*

2. Adjust the Tone

- *"Remove the 'therapy speak' and make it sound cool."*
- *"Make it very simple for a young child."*
- *"Focus on the biological science of the brain."*

3. The Repair Script

- *"My child says this breathing exercise makes them dizzy. Suggest a non-breathing alternative like 'Grounding' or 'Muscle Squeezing'."*

4. Build Your Own System

- *"Act as [Role]. My child is afraid of [Specific Fear]. The context is [Details]. Build me a [Ladder/Script/Game] to help them face it gradually."*